



◀ Group treatment

The great and the good of Paris flocked to Mesmer's ritualistic treatments in the 1780s. Even the French queen, Marie Antoinette, attended. On the left here, a woman faints, while others are seated around the *baquet* (see below).

uncontrollably, or even vomit. A contemporary English doctor noted not only the “air of mystery” that permeated the spectacle but also that “the scene was full of wonderment.”

Quack or genuine believer?

What was effectively a form of hypnosis later proved hugely influential in orthodox and complementary medicine. Mesmerism also contributed to the growth of spiritualism (see pp.224–227) and to hypnosis as a public spectacle.

At the time, Mesmer continued to press for official recognition of the existence of his vital life force. He never received it. Mesmer's treatments seemed perilously closer to the occult than to medicine, as he apparently assumed control of his patients' minds. In 1785, a royal commission ruled that there was no evidence for the magnetic force Mesmer claimed, and he was discredited.

IN PRACTICE

Mesmer's magic tub

The water-filled wooden container Mesmer called a *baquet* was the central element of his treatments and the focus of his gatherings. Iron rods projected from the *baquet*, while inside it they were inserted into cylinders, each containing a magnet to magnetize the water. The rods were bent, and Mesmer placed their ends on any given patient's afflicted area. Ropes were strung from the *baquet* to link the patients seated around it and allow more forces to flow, and the patients also held hands to spread the magnetism.

